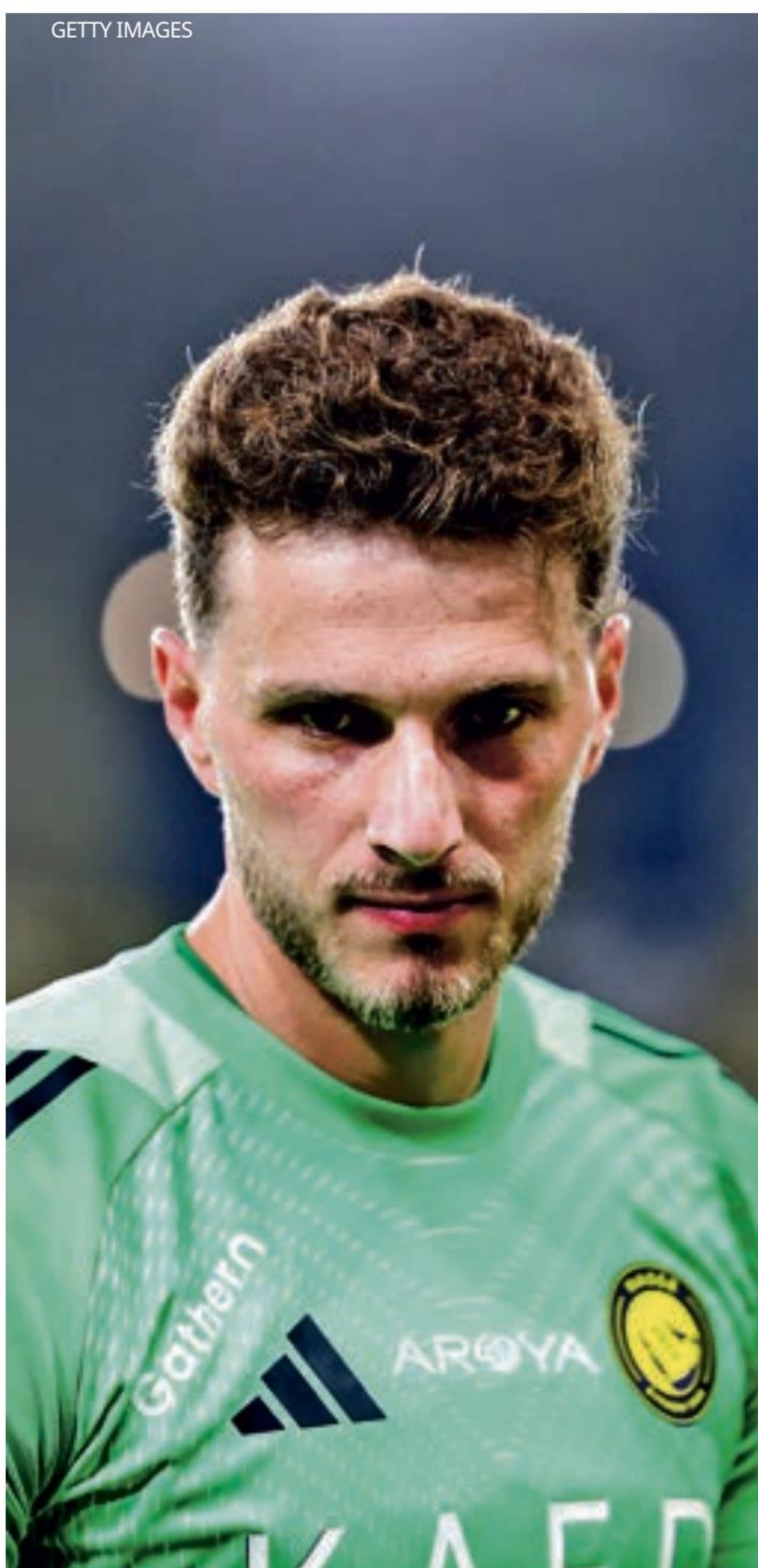




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Within a span of five days, Cristiano Ronaldo's patience was stretched thin twice, as his wait for a major trophy with Al Nassr continued. The first instance came in the Saudi Pro League. It was the Riyadh derby against Al Hilal, which featured Ronaldo's former Real Madrid teammate Karim Benzema up top.

The equation was simple Al Nassr — beat the local rival and lift the title. Since joining the Saudi outfit during the 2022-23 season, the Portugal veteran has managed to get his hands on just one trophy: the Arab Club Champions Cup in 2023.

And his wait seemed to be nearing its end when Mohamed Simakan fired home from close range in the 36th minute, a goal that remained the difference for most of regulation time. Even though Ronaldo was substituted in the 82nd minute, he watched keenly from the dugout, patiently waiting for the final whistle. But fate had other plans.

In the 90+8th minute, Nassr goalkeeper Bento **(left)**, who had otherwise enjoyed a spotless evening, spilled the ball into his own net **(above)**. He came off his line to collect a throw-in but collided with defender Inigo Martinez, failing to gather the ball cleanly. The final whistle soon followed and cameras caught Ronaldo smiling sardonically. He then walked back to the dressing room, visibly exasperated.

The second instance came in the AFC Champions League Two final, where Nassr faced Japan's Gamba Osaka. A 29th-minute strike from Deniz Hummet stood between Ronaldo and his maiden major title in Nassr colours. Once again, he trudged towards the dugout in despair and was not even seen with his teammates during the medal ceremony.